



A FREE GUIDE FROM SCRAPPY STACKS

Free to Start

Every free tool you need to get your own business
off the ground — before you spend a dime.

“Own your work. Own your life.”

Before You Start Spending

Somewhere along the way, someone convinced you that starting a business means signing up for a stack of paid tools before you've made a single dollar. A booking system, a design subscription, an accounting app, an ad platform — all before your first customer.

That's backwards. The people who actually get their business off the ground do it with what's free first, and they figure out what's worth paying for later — once it's actually making them money.

This guide is the list we hand people who are still working a job and building something of their own on the side. Nothing here costs anything. No trials that quietly start billing you. Just the tools that cover the basics so you can find out if the business works before you spend a dime proving it.

Use what applies to you. Skip what doesn't. You don't need all of it — you need the two or three that fix what's actually slowing you down right now.

The Tools, Organized by the Problem They Solve

GETTING FOUND

Google Business Profile

FOR: SHOWING UP WHEN SOMEONE SEARCHES FOR YOU

Free, and often the first thing a customer sees before your website. Claim it, keep your hours honest, and add real photos. It does more for local search than most things people pay for. (*business.google.com*)

GETTING BOOKED

Calendly (free plan)

FOR: ENDING THE “DOES TUESDAY WORK?” TEXTS

One link replaces the back-and-forth. The free plan covers one calendar, which is all you need when the business is just you. (*calendly.com*)

GETTING PAID

Wave

FOR: INVOICES AND BASIC BOOKKEEPING

Free invoicing and accounting built for a business your size, not a Fortune 500. Send a professional invoice the same day you take on a client. (*waveapps.com*)

GETTING WRITTEN

ChatGPT (free plan)

FOR: THE REPLY OR POST YOU KEEP PUTTING OFF

Paste in rough notes and ask it to sound like you. It doesn't know your business until you tell it, so treat it as a starting draft, not a finished answer. (*chatgpt.com*)

GETTING SEEN

Canva (free plan)

FOR: A QUICK GRAPHIC OR SOCIAL POST

Fine for a fast announcement between bigger pieces. It won't build you a real brand on its own, but it covers the gap when you need something today. (*canva.com*)

GETTING ORGANIZED

Google Docs & Sheets

FOR: CONTRACTS, TRACKING, AND NOT LOSING TRACK OF ANYTHING

Free, shareable, and already familiar. Enough to track jobs, quotes, and simple contracts until you outgrow a spreadsheet. (*docs.google.com*)

What This Guide Won't Do

It won't set up your LLC, open your business bank account, or draft your contracts — that's paperwork most people put off for good reason, and it's not something a free tool does well.

It won't build you a real website or a brand people remember either. Free tools are good at getting you moving. They're not built to make you look like you've been in business for ten years.

That's the point where most people either spend months learning it themselves, or hand it to someone else and get back to actually running the business.

When Free Stops Being Enough

Starter gets the paperwork and the website handled — done for you, starting at \$697/mo.

Premium adds AI running your busywork on top of that, starting at \$997/mo.

No contracts. Pause or cancel anytime. Every file is yours to keep, always.

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